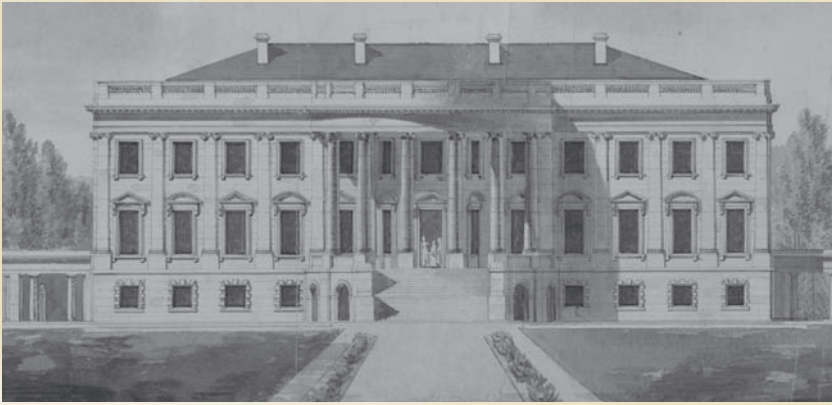




The White House

Work on the US president's official residence began in 1792 after a design by Irish architect James Hoban was chosen by George Washington from among nine competition entries. The building was first occupied in 1800. After being burned by the British in 1814, it was restored and painted white.

1708 Black slaves outnumber white inhabitants in the Carolinas for the first time. Over the next 50 years, thousands of slaves arrive in the colonies each year.

1709 Work begins on a slave market at the end of Wall Street in New York City.

1713 England assumes a dominant role in the transatlantic slave trade after Queen Anne's War.

1738 Escaped slaves establish the first free black township in the Americas at Fort Mose in Florida.

1744–48 After a lengthy period of sometimes uneasy peace, France and Britain continue their rivalry in North America during King George's War (known in Europe as the War of the Austrian Succession). After unsuccessful British and Iroquois raids on New France (along the St. Lawrence River in Canada), the French and their Huron allies raid Maine and New York. Hostilities continue after the war in the Ohio River valley, where the French try to halt British expansion westward by destroying Fort Pickawillany in 1752.

1750 The slave population of the English colonies reaches 236,400, of whom more than 200,000 live south of Pennsylvania. A decade later, their total population reaches 325,806.

1755–63 The French and Indian War is the most decisive phase of the lengthy Anglo-French conflict in North America and is the American counterpart of the Seven Years War in Europe. The French are at a disadvantage because their total number of colonists in North America is only one-tenth that of the British colonies, while Britain's Royal Navy is able to stop trade and troop reinforcements from reaching French colonies. Initially the French have some successes, but after their defeat in Canada in 1759, the British are supreme. Under the Treaty of Paris that ends the war, Britain gains control over French Canada and that portion of Louisiana lying east of the Mississippi River. Spain surrenders Florida to the British.

1763 Britain sets a Proclamation Line defining the limit to the westward expansion of its 13 American colonies. The 1774 Québec Act extends British Canada's boundaries south to the Ohio and Mississippi rivers. Both measures are widely seen as restrictive limits on colonial freedom and expansion.

1765 The British government imposes direct taxation on its American colonies for the first time in order to pay for the recent war and the cost of keeping a large army in the Americas. The Stamp Act, which places a tax on newspapers and other items, is widely resented and, after much opposition, is repealed in 1766.

1766 The Declaratory Act affirms Britain's right to legislate in its 13 American colonies.

1769–74 In just five years, ships from Irish ports alone bring 44,000 new colonists to British North America. By 1774 there are more than 2 million Europeans on the continent. Scots, Irish, Germans, and others swell the numbers. Not all of them support the British crown.

1770 British troops kill three and mortally wound five Bostonians, adding to the tension between Britain and its increasingly rebellious colonists.

1773 Massachusetts citizens board three ships in Boston Harbor and throw their cargo overboard in protest against the imposition of a tea tax.

“We hold these truths to be self-evident, that all men are created **equal**”

US DECLARATION OF INDEPENDENCE
JULY 4, 1776

1775–81 The American Revolution breaks out as colonists clash with British troops at Lexington and Concord near Boston on April 19, 1775. Forces of the 13 rebel colonies, led after June by George Washington, struggle at first but eventually overwhelm the British, with French and Spanish support. The victory of the French fleet over the British off the Chesapeake Capes forces the surrender of the British at Yorktown in 1781.

1776 The Declaration of Independence is drafted by Thomas Jefferson. It states, among other things, that people have “certain unalienable rights, that among these are life, liberty, and the pursuit of happiness.”

1783 Under the Treaty of Paris, Britain recognizes the independence of the United States. Florida is restored to Spain. The western border of the new state stretches to the Mississippi River.

1787 A Constitutional Convention, held in Philadelphia, revises the Articles of Confederation, originally agreed in 1777, by drafting a new Constitution for the federation of the 13 states.

1787–90 The new Constitution is ratified by the 13 states; it is officially accepted on June 21, 1788, after the number of states ratifying it reaches nine, the required two-thirds level of approval.

1789 George Washington is elected first president of the United States in February, and the first Congress meets in New York City, the designated seat of federal government. The Supreme Court is established in September.

1790, 1791 The District of Columbia is established under Acts of Congress on land ceded by the states of Maryland and Virginia, to become the new site of the federal capital. The site, on the Potomac River, is chosen by George Washington. In 1800 the federal government moves from Philadelphia to begin work in Washington; the same year, John Adams becomes the first president to live in the White House.

1791 Ten amendments to the Constitution guaranteeing freedom of speech, assembly, and other rights, come into effect as the Bill of Rights.

1797 George Washington steps down as president after two terms (he was reelected in 1792) and is succeeded by his vice president, John Adams. Washington dies in 1799 at his home at Mount Vernon, Virginia.

1801 Thomas Jefferson is elected third president after a dead heat in the electoral college with Aaron Burr. The matter is decided by the House of Representatives, who make their choice after 36 ballots.

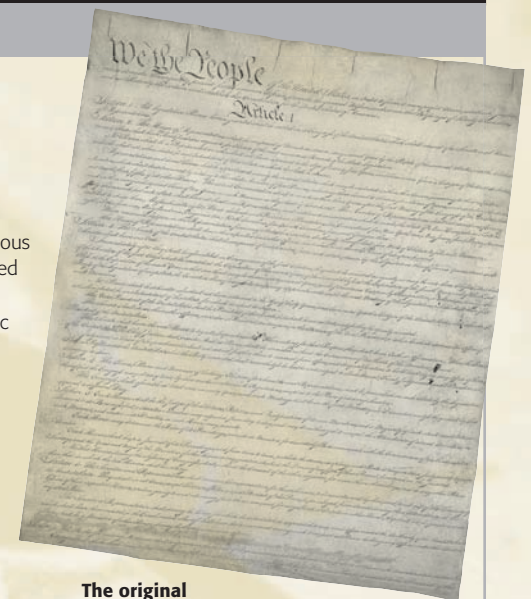
DECISIVE MOMENT

THE US CONSTITUTION

The US Constitution (right) was drawn up by the Constitutional Convention in Philadelphia in 1787 and finalized on September 17. It came into force after nine states had ratified it by June 21, 1788.

The Constitution opens with the famous preamble: “We, the people of the United States, in order to form a more perfect union, establish justice, insure domestic tranquility, provide for the common defense, promote the general welfare, and secure the blessings of liberty to ourselves and our posterity, do ordain and establish this Constitution for the United States of America.”

The document then spells out in seven articles how the new country is to be governed. It establishes the three branches of government—the legislative (Congress), the executive (the presidency), and the judiciary (the courts)—and builds in checks and balances so that each acts as a restraint on the actions of the other two. Congress is to consist of two houses: the lower House of Representatives, whose elected members are drawn from each state in proportion to its population, and the upper Senate, consisting of two elected members from each state. Alongside the federal structure of government established by the Constitution, state and local governments complete the American system of democratic government.



The original
1787 draft

Article V of the Constitution allows for it to be amended. This has occurred 27 times, most recently in 1992. Notable amendments are the first 10, known together as the Bill of Rights, which were added in 1791.

Subsequent important amendments include the 13th, abolishing slavery in 1865; the 15th, establishing equal voting rights for blacks and whites in 1870; the 18th, prohibiting the sale of alcohol in 1919; and the 19th, granting votes to women in 1920. The 21st Amendment of 1933 repealed the 18th, allowing Americans to drink legally once again.